

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Getty Images

Oil prices fell to their lowest in nearly two weeks after Axios reported that the White House believes **America** and **Iran** are close to a deal to end the war. Brent crude fell by 8% to \$101 a barrel. Earlier Donald Trump announced a pause on America's operation to [guide commercial ships](#) out of the Strait of Hormuz, citing progress in negotiations.

Global stockmarkets rose on the news of a possible de-escalation. Europe's STOXX 600 and Britain's FTSE 100 indices each gained over 2%. America's S&P 500 and tech-heavy Nasdaq indices climbed both by 1% respectively when markets opened, reaching record highs. Government bonds also rallied; yields on American ten-year Treasuries fell by 0.06 percentage points to 4.36%.

Australia committed more than A\$10bn (\$7.2bn) to boost its stockpiles of aviation fuel, diesel and petrol and establish a reserve of around 1bn litres. Anthony Albanese, the prime minister, said that will ensure the country has at least 50 days of fuel onshore to protect it from supply shocks. Australia, which imports 80% of its fuel, has faced shortages since the war in Iran began.

America's **Securities and Exchange Commission** proposed scrapping a requirement for public companies to report **quarterly**

earnings, allowing them to file twice a year instead. Mr Trump [floated the idea](#) last year and during his first term. The regulator's chair said the "rigidity" of the current rules may be inhibiting businesses and investors. The SEC will vote on the rule after a 60-day public-comment period.

Novo Nordisk lifted its forecast of sales and profits for the year after reporting better-than-expected first-quarter results. Its Wegovy weight-loss pill, which was approved by America in December, helped it to compete with Eli Lilly, an American rival. The Danish drugmaker now expects sales to fall by 4-12% this year, less than the 5-13% decline it predicted previously. Margins are under pressure because of [price competition](#).

Russian bombs killed at least 20 people and wounded dozens in several cities in **Ukraine**. The attacks came before the start of a two-day ceasefire declared by Vladimir Putin to observe a holiday marking Russia's victory in the second world war. [Volodymyr Zelensky](#), Ukraine's president, called the strikes "absolutely cynical". Ukraine has begun its own open-ended ceasefire.

Five book **publishers**, including Hachette and Macmillan, filed a class-action lawsuit against **Meta**. They accused the technology giant of lifting [copyrighted material](#) from pirate websites to train its artificial-intelligence platform, Llama. Meta said that its practice is "fair use" of copyrighted material and vowed to fight the lawsuit "aggressively". Authors have previously sued the company for similar reasons.

Figure of the day: €150bn (\$176bn), what the European Union's reporting requirements and other paperwork cumulatively cost European businesses each year, according to the bloc's statistics agency. [Read about](#) the EU's overregulation of companies.



Photograph: Getty Images

The G7's trade dilemma

Donald Trump's trade war continues to unsettle the world economy. After a surprisingly strong year in 2025, when demand for AI-related goods like chips caused global trade to grow by nearly 5%, the outlook has darkened. Oxford Economics, a consultancy, expects goods trade to grow by just 2.5% this year. [Tariffs](#) are the main culprit. In America more than 60 Section 301 investigations (the legal mechanism by which levies are imposed) are under way. Last week Mr Trump threatened to raise tariffs on European cars to 25%.

On Wednesday trade ministers from the G7, a club of the world's largest rich democracies, meet in France. They will discuss China's industrial overcapacity, fragile critical-mineral supply chains and the future of the World Trade Organisation. Yet the world's largest economy shows little appetite for co-operation. After a fruitless WTO meeting in March, America's trade envoy dismissed the body as irrelevant. The G7 may seek co-ordination. America has, thus far, chosen confrontation.



Photograph: Getty Images

An unhappy birthday for Germany's government

One year ago Friedrich Merz took office as Germany's chancellor. The coalition he formed, which united his conservative bloc with the Social Democrats, was a coupling of convenience rather than love. But the parties' leaders seemed committed to working together to lift the country from the economic doldrums in which it had long languished. An early decision to [boost defence](#) and infrastructure spending impressed allies and markets.

But the government marks its first birthday in miserable shape. Both parties have lost ground in polls since last year's election. The populist-right Alternative for Germany has opened up its first-ever meaningful lead. Mr Merz, who has lately been embroiled in a [nasty spat](#) with Donald Trump, enjoys an approval rating of just 13%. The parties' endless bickering over domestic reforms has led some to speculate whether their coalition might collapse. And with bigger battles to come over taxes and pensions, it is hard to see the mood improving.



Photograph: EPA

Another Epstein deposition in Congress

On Wednesday Howard Lutnick, America's commerce secretary, will testify before the House Oversight Committee about his relationship with Jeffrey Epstein. The deposition, which takes place behind closed doors, is part of a broader inquiry into Epstein, which seeks to uncover how the dead sex offender grew to be so wealthy and well connected, and how he [evaded accountability](#) for so long.

Members will probably grill Mr Lutnick over his claim to have cut contact with Epstein in 2005, after the financier was first investigated for soliciting underage sex. Documents released by the Department of Justice instead suggest that the two men were in touch years later. In 2012, when Mr Lutnick ran Cantor Fitzgerald, a brokerage firm and investment bank, they had lunch on Epstein's island in the Caribbean.

The committee has already questioned a number of politicians and high-profile people, some of whom are close to Donald Trump, over their [links to Epstein](#) to understand who may have been complicit in his crimes.



Photograph: Shutterstock

Is the fake-meat industry cooked?

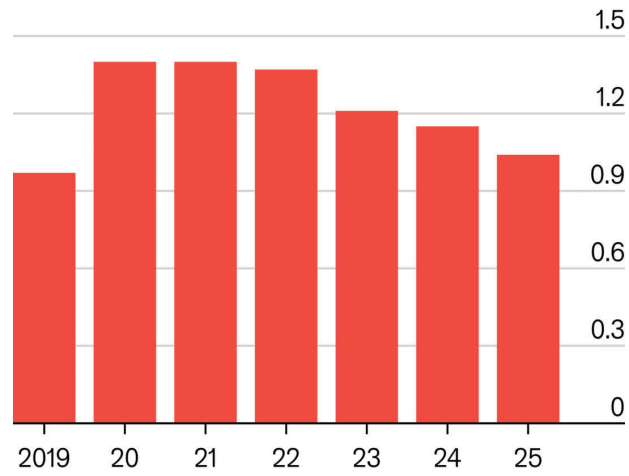
Investors may feel queasy when Beyond, a maker of meat-free burgers, reports quarterly earnings on Wednesday. Since the company went public in 2019 its market value has plummeted from almost \$4bn to less than \$450m. The company has forecast revenues of \$57m-59m for the first quarter of 2026, a decline of up to 17% year on year.

Beyond is suffering because consumers' behaviour has changed. Some are increasingly [reluctant to fork out](#) for plant-based alternatives to meat, which cost more than the real thing. Others are put off by long ingredient lists and complicated production processes, which makes them ultra-processed foods.

However, Beyond is hoping that [the rise of high-protein diets](#) will have more consumers licking their lips. It now calls itself a “Plant Protein Company”, displays its protein content prominently on its packaging and recently launched a line of canned protein drinks. But that has not bulked up sales yet.

Leaving the feast

United States, sales of plant-based meat, \$bn



Source: Good Food Institute



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Wednesday: Andy Summers was the guitarist of which British rock band?

Tuesday: John Fogerty was the main songwriter of which rock group?

*Being entirely honest with oneself
is a good exercise.*

Sigmund Freud